

Problems of objectivity in Anthropological research

Anthropological research involves use of variety of methods like Participant observation, Questionnaire, Schedules, etc to ensure objectivity in research. However, there are many concerns with respect to ensuring objectivity.

Some issues objectivity are:

- ① Post Modernist school criticise Participant observation suggesting the power-relations between community and ethnographer and questioned objectivity of the method.
- ② Presence of outsiders may lead to natives not showing their true behaviour.
- ③ Emic vs Etic debate: Schools like Evolutionists, Functionalists, Materialist focussed more on etic i.e. outsider's perspective and not emic i.e. insider's perspective.

- ④ Researchers have their own biases from their own culture which may impact research.
- ⑤ Power hierarchies and Purpose of research:
For Ex, Many British anthropologist showed India as a backward, degrading society to suit their colonial interests.

Ways of ensuring objectivity

- ① Approach of New Ethnography or Cognitive Anthropology which calls for learning native conceptual categories via linguistic analysis.
- ② Interpretive approach of Geertz call for ~~extra~~ giving thick description by stepping in shoes of natives.
- ③ Reflexivity: Acknowledging one's own biases and re-evaluating research in light of those biases.